# GitHub, 9 disruptions in 10 days.

```
$ git pull
Permission denied (publickey).
```

What's going on?

Sources: GitHub, Hacker News.

TC
**Teodoro Corbo**
independent analysis

# 4 November: two hours of stuck pipelines.

In the morning we get an urgent call. The error message points at our key: we're the first suspects.

- [x] ~~expired keys~~
- [x] ~~authentication~~
- [x] ~~access permissions~~




After the checks, only one suspect is left.

# The error fooled others too.

```
$ git pull
git@github.com: Permission denied (publickey).
fatal: Could not read from remote repository.

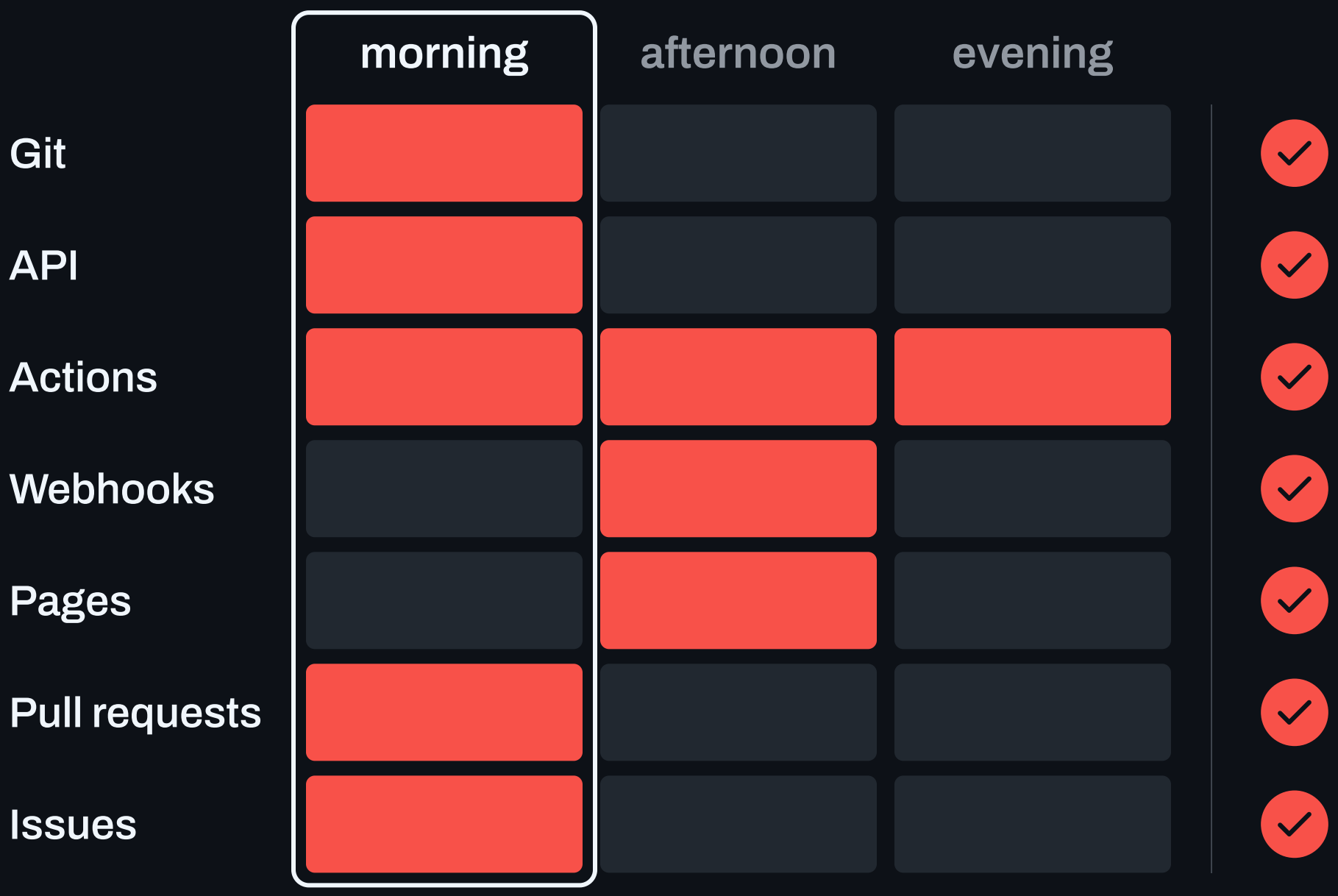
Please make sure you have the correct access rights
and the repository exists.
# the same key sometimes worked
```

On Hacker News, some people thought their SSH key had been breached.

Sources: GitHub, Hacker News.

# Three disruptions, from morning to evening.

Each column is a disruption, each row a service. Red: the services hit.

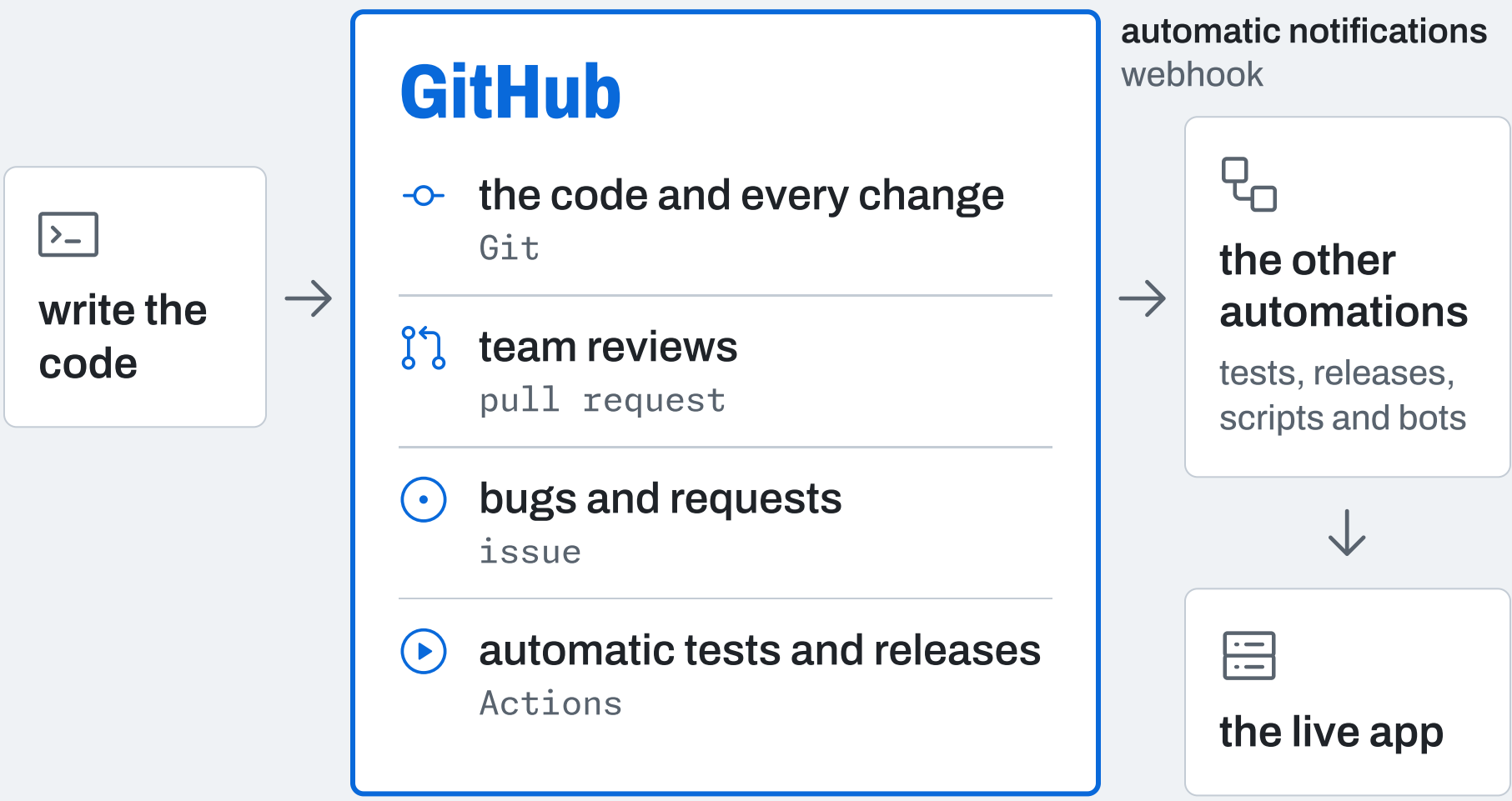



The first one matches our morning.

Source: GitHub.

# GitHub is the road from code to the live app.

Developers keep their code there, and their teams review it. For many, tests and releases start there too: when it's disrupted, everything downstream feels it.




Source: GitHub.

# 8 in 10 developers use it.




8 in 10 of those who answered the Stack Overflow 2025 survey. On average, **124 million** automated jobs run on Actions daily.

Sources: GitHub, Microsoft, Stack Overflow.

# 294

## incidents in 12 months

on average, over the last year

**0.8 a day**

from 26 October to 4 November

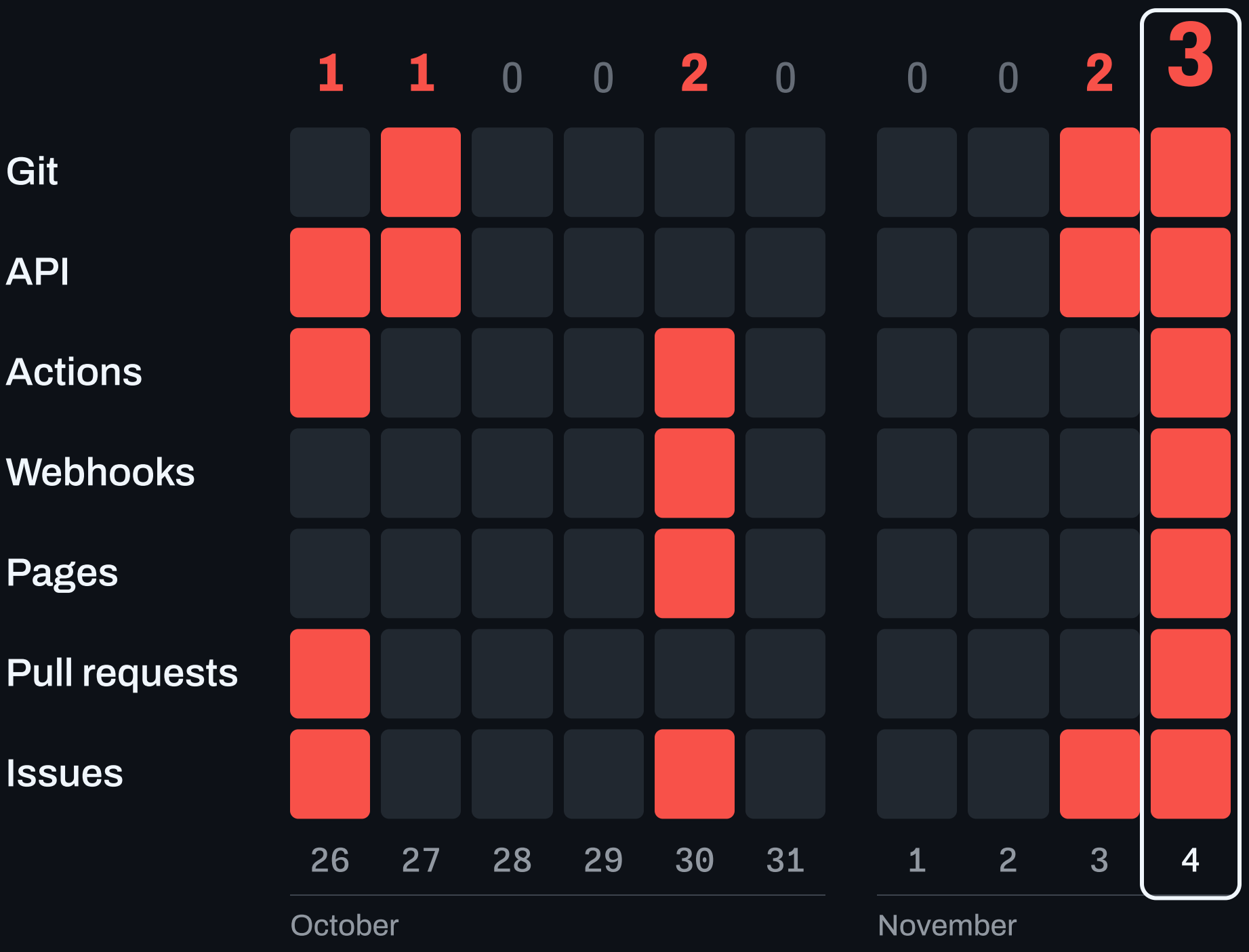
**1.4 a day**

That's 14 in the ten days, counting every published incident, including those that only hit Copilot or Dependabot.

Source: GitHub.

# Every service was hit at least twice.

One column per day, one row per service. Along the top, disruptions per day; in red, the services hit.




Source: GitHub.

# 2 of 9

## disruptions have an explanation



Filled: explained. Empty: not yet.

The one during our two hours is among the seven still unexplained. GitHub publishes a report every month: September's came out on 14 October.

Source: GitHub.

# The causes: a database and too many retries.

## 27 October

At times, existing repositories come back “not found”.

Why: reads were moved to a new database while the data copy was lagging.

## 30 October, evening

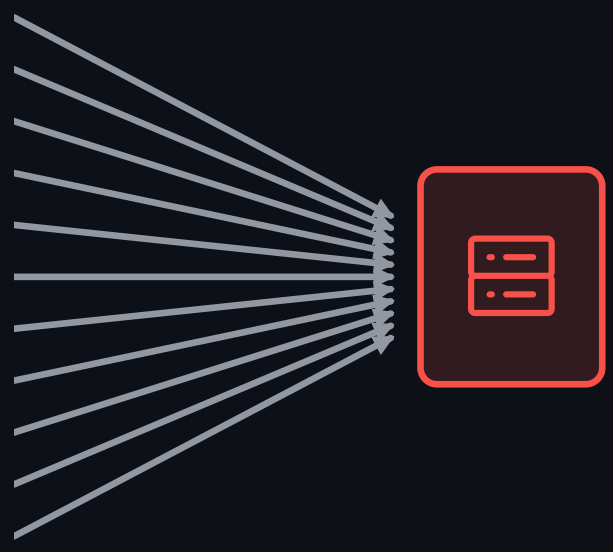
Actions, Pages and webhooks delayed.

Why: a service was retrying its connections too aggressively.

Source: GitHub.

# The storm that keeps coming back.

about **90%**



of connection attempts were failing, on 30 October

When a service doesn't respond, clients retry. If they all retry at once, with no pause, traffic snowballs and drags down even what was still working.




**At least four times since August.** Each time, GitHub's fixes include a change to retries.

Source: GitHub.

# Three questions for your automations.

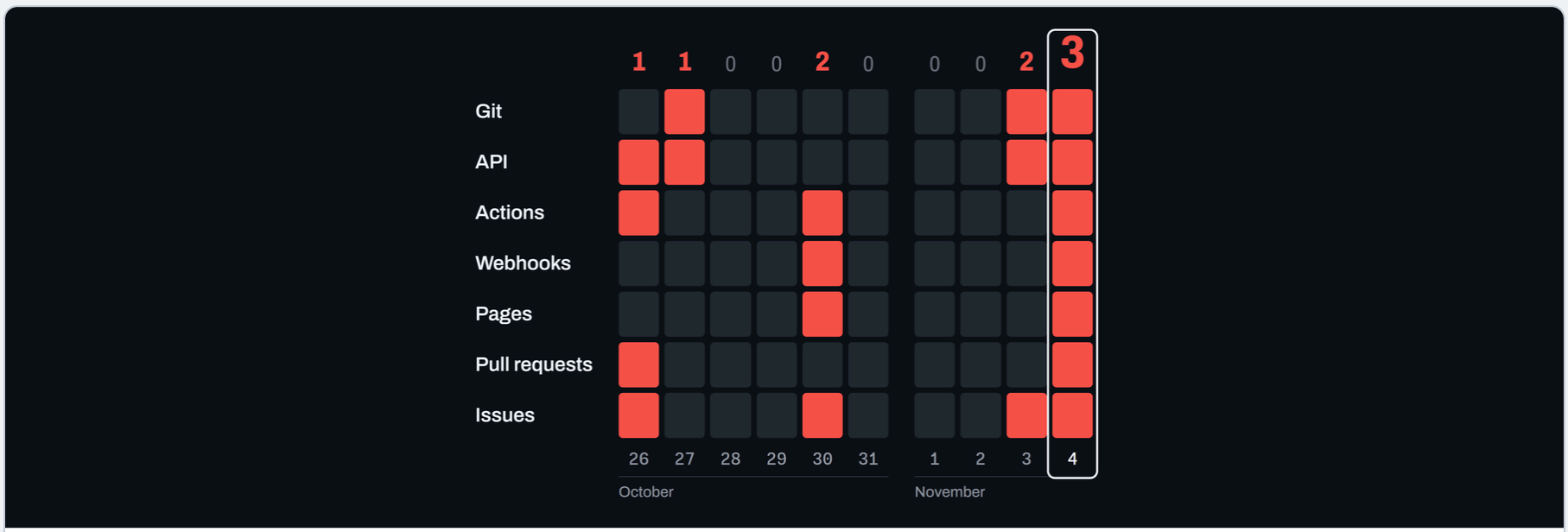



1. When it doesn't respond, do they retry? How many times, and how long do they wait?

2. If one of its notifications gets lost, does anything still kick off? Would anyone notice?

3. If the error says “not found” or “permission denied”, can you tell whether the problem is on your side or theirs?

# The full analysis is on the site.




## Nine disruptions in ten days: what happened at GitHub

`teodoro98.github.io/en/analysis/github-2026-11`

With every source, the timing of each disruption and the published causes.

## Link in the first comment.

Ever chased a permissions error that wasn't yours?